Grading & The Revenue Ladder

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Published in week 0. No surprises: this is exactly how your semester is evaluated.

The One Principle

Evidence quality and decision discipline weigh as much as revenue. This course grades how well you ran the experiment called “your startup” — not just how much money came out of it. A rigorously argued kill with a documented evidence pack can earn an A. A zombie project limping to demo day cannot.

The Rubric

Dimension	Weight	What an A looks like
Evidence quality	30%	Interview logs with named contacts and verbatim quotes · pre-committed thresholds in the Kill Criteria Log · UTM-verified traffic · honest small-n read-outs. Your Toolkit tells a complete, auditable story.
Decision discipline	30%	You wrote pass/fail lines BEFORE tests and honored them · Go/Pivot/Kill decisions argued from data, not attachment · pivots and kills documented with what the evidence said.
Verified traction	30%	Progress along the Revenue Ladder (below) · revenue quality (repeatable > consulting) · outside-social-graph, dashboard-verified.
Communication	10%	Demo-day pitch: clear problem evidence, honest numbers, a story that survives Q&A.

The A-Kill (yes, really)

A team that: ran 25+ real interviews, launched a landing page against a pre-committed threshold, built and shipped a prototype, ran the riskiest-assumption test, and then **killed the idea in Module 07 with a documented autopsy** — then restarted via the concierge ramp and sold ANYTHING by demo day — has demonstrated more entrepreneurial skill than a team that limped to €800 on favors. Grade accordingly: that’s an A trajectory.

What an A-kill requires: the full evidence pack, the pre-committed kill criterion it violated, the Kill Ritual one-pager, and a demo-day presentation of what was learned and what came next.

The Revenue Ladder

Week	Pass bar	Stretch (leaderboard)
Module 08	First € from outside your social graph	3 paying users
Module 09	€500 cumulative	€1,000
Module 10	€1,000	€3,000
Module 11	€2,000	€5,000
Demo Day	**€1,000 verified minimum + evidence pack**	**The €10,000 club**

What counts: revenue from outside your social graph only, meaning people you did not know before this venture (no friends, family, classmates, course teams) · any amount, a paid deposit or pre-order too · verified via payment dashboard or a paid numbered invoice · repeatable revenue (same offer, >1 customer, no custom scope) ranks above consulting-style projects · “paid twice” beats “paid once.” A signed pilot or letter of intent without payment is signal, not revenue.

What doesn’t count: favor purchases, team-to-team purchases inside the course, unverifiable cash, revenue you can’t show a dashboard or invoice for.

Anti-Fake Rules (published, so nobody is surprised)

Interviews require named contacts + one verbatim quote each in the Toolkit; random 60-second recording spot-checks happen in check-ins. Landing-page traffic requires the UTM source report; only target-segment conversions count. To read a landing-page line, compare it with Unbounce’s 2024 medians for SaaS landing pages, 16.9% for email traffic (warm), 4.1% for paid search and 2.9% for paid social (cold), where a conversion is any click or form event (Unbounce, 2024). AI-simulated users are allowed for PREP only, never as evidence, and must be labeled.

Questions about a specific case (e.g., a B2B pilot with a long payment cycle)? Ask before the deadline, not after. Reasonable evidence of a signed, dated pilot agreement can count at instructor discretion.